EU-China shipping check-in

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SNEAK PEEK

—EU and Chinese officials are sitting down today for a shipping dialogue covering everything from ports to the green transition.

—The Commission is preparing to introduce measures to strengthen airport infrastructure resilience and expand support for smaller airports.

— EU leaders discussed Friday how to keep Ukrainian cargo lanes moving, focusing on restoring Black Sea shipping and on strengthening land and river routes through Europe.

Good morning, and welcome to Morning Mobility.

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DRIVING THE DAY

EU-CHINA SHIPPING CHECK-IN: EU and Chinese officials are sitting down today for a broad shipping dialogue covering everything from ports to the green transition, as the shipping world prepares for the next IMO session and faces an increasingly turbulent global backdrop.

What's on the table: The agenda is expected to run through the latest port policies, green shipping corridors and cleaner marine fuels, before getting into the more politically charged stuff — namely, the International Maritime Organization's Net-Zero Framework to cut shipping emissions, and the interconnected EU Emissions Trading System.

On the climate bit: World governments are heading into another crunch period on the IMO's Net-Zero Framework, with technical talks due in late November and the formal adoption fight expected to return in early December. China struck a more conciliatory tone in the September round and, crucially, came out more clearly in favor of the framework — a shift everyone is watching as the U.S. and oil-producing countries such as Saudi Arabia and Russia keep pushing back against the deal.

Shipbuilding elephant: China, meanwhile, is also still the giant of global shipbuilding, leading in several major vessel categories. Brussels is trying to claw back some ground with its new European maritime

industrial strategy, which is meant to bolster the bloc's shipyards, maritime technology and industrial resilience while backing the sector's green and digital transition.

Who's there: The EU delegation is being led by Fotini Ioannidou, director for waterborne transport at the European Commission's mobility and transport department, DG MOVE, one Commission official told POLITICO. Representatives from the shipping industry and national EU governments are also expected.

AVIATION

COMMISSION TO FOCUS ON AIRPORTS IN UPCOMING POLICY INITIATIVES: Airports will soon be back in the spotlight as Brussels prepares several legislative and non-legislative initiatives. "Well-functioning, competitive airports" were among the six priorities identified by DG MOVE Director General Magda Kopczyńska for the Commission's upcoming aviation strategy during her speech at last week's IATA conference.

State of play: The EU executive is already reviewing airport financing rules through its proposed revision of the General Block Exemption Regulation (GBER), the EU's main framework for allowing governments to grant certain types of state aid without prior notification to the Commission. Recent drafts of the regulation — which is currently awaiting its final adoption — have raised concerns about potential restrictions on aid for smaller airports.

Brussels' response: "The maximum aid intensity for investment aid to airports serving up to 500,000 passengers per year will increase to 100% of costs," said Ricardo Cardoso, the Commission's competition spokesperson. "This is compared to a maximum aid intensity of 75% under the current GBER," he told Tommaso.

Small airports, read this: The latest text extends from 100 to 150 kilometers the radius within which proximity to another airport can limit eligibility for investment aid. "While the new revised GBER rules still include a catchment area test, this only applies to airports with more than 500,000 passengers per year," Cardoso said. "Under the current rules the equivalent number is 200,000 passengers per year. This means an additional 50 airports will be able to benefit from block-exempted investment aid," he said, arguing that the revised rules would ultimately benefit rather than disadvantage smaller airports.

What's next? In her speech last week, Kopczyńska confirmed that airports will remain eligible for EU infrastructure funding under the next long-term budget. Airports, she said, "will continue to be supported also in financing programs of the next multiannual financial framework," reflecting their growing role beyond passenger transport. "They are becoming important energy hubs … digital platforms [and] dual-use assets," she added.

Reforms are coming: Kopczyńska said the Commission is "about to finalize" the so-called fitness check of airport legislation, which may lead to legislative proposals to reform rules on slots, airport charges and ground handling services.

New threats: The DG MOVE director general also highlighted emerging aviation security threats, including cybersecurity risks, GPS jamming and spoofing and drone incursions. "There is a security dimension, but there's also an infrastructure dimension … and if airports are not critical infrastructure, then I do not know what is," Kopczyńska said, stressing the role airports play in strengthening the EU's resilience against hybrid threats.

AIRLINE LOBBY SPELLS OUT PRIORITIES FOR AIRPORT REFORMS: IATA's Thomas Reynaert outlined the airline industry's priorities for the upcoming legislative reforms affecting airports. Carriers want

greater scrutiny of airports that, because of their location, enjoy significant market power, he said.

Monopoly matters: “Very often, these are monopolies,” Reynaert told Tommaso, citing Brussels Airport in Zaventem as an example. Airlines often have little choice but to use such airports, giving the latter considerable leverage over the fees they charge. “We’re not saying that they’re all abusing their position, but the regulator … needs to look into this,” he added.

Charges problem: One issue is how airports use revenue from their commercial activities — such as shops, restaurants and car parks — when setting the fees airlines pay to land and take off. Airports with significant market power tend to favour a “dual-till” model, Reynaert said, which treats aviation and commercial activities within the airport as separate businesses.

Single vs. dual till: Under this model, revenue from shops, parking and other commercial services is excluded when calculating aviation charges for airlines. IATA argues that this revenue is generated in large part by passengers brought in by airlines and should therefore help offset airport costs, reducing the fees carriers pay. That approach, known as “single till,” would take commercial revenue into account when setting aviation charges.

On ground handling, IATA argues that “the current directive has not done enough to create competition in the market,” Reynaert said, pointing to major airports where only a small number of ground handling companies provide essential services to airlines.

However, he questioned whether new legislation alone could address the lack of competition. “It’s probably more something the competition authorities will need to look into,” he added.

Leave slots as they are: As for the rules governing the allocation of airport slots, the current regulation “works well,” Reynaert said, noting that “there’s no need to change the slots regulation.”

MARITIME

HOPE FOR BLACK SEA: EU leaders discussed on Friday how to step up efforts to keep Ukrainian cargo lanes moving, focusing both on restoring safer Black Sea shipping and on strengthening land and river routes through Europe.

All quiet on the grain front: Ukrainian farmers are still stuck with millions of tons of grain they can’t sell. Russia bombs Ukrainian ships, Ukrainians bomb Russian ones, and the exports must increasingly move via land and river routes through Europe, which can still carry only about half of what is needed, Ukrainian Agriculture Minister Taras Vysotskyi told our colleague Agnes Rønberg on Friday. At the latest Council of EU agriculture ministers, Vysotskyi had asked for more capacity and financing for extra shipping costs, but said he still hasn’t received a reply.

Black Sea security moves up the list: On Friday, the second day of the European Council summit, leaders condemned recent attacks on civilian and commercial shipping in Romania’s and Bulgaria’s exclusive economic zones and called for the “immediate restoration of safe passage” in the Black Sea. According to an EU diplomat, granted anonymity to speak freely about discussions inside the room, Romanian President Nicu□or Dan also pushed for more maritime protection, counter-drone support and help operationalizing a Black Sea Maritime Security Hub led with Bulgaria.

NATO in the frame: Dan also said Romania coordinated closely with Bulgaria, including through a joint meeting with NATO Secretary-General Mark Rutte, who he said reaffirmed the alliance’s commitment to strengthening its eastern flank and counter-drone capabilities.

And the land routes: Leaders also stressed the need to further consolidate the so-called Solidarity Lanes, the rail, road, river and port routes through Europe that help Ukrainian goods reach world markets. What that means in practice remains unclear. So far, Romania and Poland have said they can't do much more to increase capacity, with trucks loaded with grain already queuing at ports and border crossings.

TRANSPORT BUDGET

CEF VOTE RACES AHEAD: Parliament's Transport and Industry Committees are aiming to adopt their position on the next Connecting Europe Facility on Nov. 10, one person involved in the matter told Martina.

What happens next: The joint TRAN/ITRE vote is expected to set Parliament's negotiating position on CEF, but it is still unclear whether lawmakers will immediately seek a mandate to enter trilogues or whether the file will first go to a plenary vote.

Why it matters: The timing comes as the CEF budget itself is under pressure in the wider 2028-2034 EU budget talks, so Parliament could lock in its policy position on how the fund should work well before governments settle how much money will actually be available.

PIT STOPS

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